

remained in a narrow range, there were enough non-index stocks making money for investors. But once the public issue market began to dry up, the secondary market soon began to show withdrawal symptoms.

Towards the end of this phase, my bets in the grey market for IPOs fared badly and I lost a handsome sum. But by then trading was not my only source of income. My ability to find counterparties for investors looking to buy or sell large blocks of shares helped me carve out a niche for myself. As I said earlier, despite the improved transparency and liquidity, it was not easy to buy or sell big quantities of shares through the screen at the push of a button. These trades would have to be first negotiated over the telephone and then put through the screen.

Soon I grew into something of an inter-institutional broker – or a broker's broker, a more apt term to describe my activity – of whom there were not many on Dalal Street. All I had to do was to point out the interested buyer or seller, and I would get a small fee for my effort. The role required me to be well networked with financial institutions, big brokers and high net worth individuals (HNIs). There were occasions when the temptation to make unethical profits from the information I was privy to tested my willpower. I was on good terms with the dealers at most of the foreign broking firms because of my regular interactions with them. A few of them did proposition me with the lure of a share in the profits. I politely declined, not knowing who might be making a genuine offer and who was simply checking me out.

One of those who made me a proposition, a Punjabi whom I shall call Lucky, persisted in dangling the bait at me. I had to be careful not to offend him because he worked for one of the top broking firms and regularly did business with me.

‘What are you trying to prove, Lala? One can't take this high-stress job for long. Make money when you get the opportunity so that you can be out of this game by forty,’ he once told me. Like mine, Lucky's too was a rags-to-riches story. He started his working career as an insurance salesman, straying into the broking industry by a quirk of fate and doing well for himself. He lacked refinement, but his street-smart ways and good relationships with people who mattered helped him land a job as a dealer at a foreign brokerage that was among the early entrants in the Indian market.

I had heard many stories about Lucky, one of them about his being on very good terms with a market operator who had got him the job at the